

پر نیا



By: Mohd Danish Kamal

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Pernia

در خاموشی، صدای حق شنیده می شود

In silence, the voice of truth is heard.

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The withdrawal of American forces from Afghanistan triggers a wave of change. Over the next few weeks, cities that were once secure begin to fall, and the balance of power shifts rapidly. باد که "به درختان می وزد، برگ های زرد از آن می افتند —When the wind blows, the yellow leaves fall from the trees. The security forces, unable to maintain control, retreat. Kabul's streets fill with anxious crowds, all uncertain about the future. On August 15th, President Ashraf Ghani flees the country, leaving the capital in turmoil. As the country's leadership falters, unease spreads throughout the nation. Flights are canceled, and chaos ensues as people scramble to leave. Kabul, once a symbol of hope and stability, now faces an uncertain future.

Sophia sat at her desk in the afternoon sun, her books scattered around her, the deadline for her economics homework looming the next day. She focused intently on the equations, unaware of the political changes happening outside her window. Her pen moved swiftly, writing down the final calculations, her mind absorbed in the world of numbers, untouched by the chaos in her country. The

soft sound of her mother's recitations of namaz filled the room, a calming presence as Sophia continued her work.

After a few minutes, her mother completed her namaz and quietly moved over to Sophia's desk. She placed a gentle hand on her daughter's shoulder. "خداوند تو را موفق بدارد، دخترم" (Khodaavand to ra movafagh bedârad, dokhtaram) — "May God grant you success, my daughter," her mother said, her voice warm, though there was an undercurrent of concern in her tone.

Sophia looked up, startled. "Thank you, Mom," she replied, offering a smile, though something in her mother's gaze made her pause. Her mother, with a soft smile, continued, "تو همیشه باید از خداوند بخوای که در هر " (To hameshe bâyard az Khodâvand bekhâhi ke dar har râhi ke miravi, hamrâhat bâshad) — "You should always ask God to be with you in every path you walk."

Sophia nodded, feeling comforted by her mother's presence. Though the words held a sense of peace, a lingering feeling of unease began to settle in her

chest, as if something larger was unfolding, just beyond her awareness.

The next morning, Sophia awoke to the sound of the birds outside her window. The sunlight filtered softly through the curtains, and for a brief moment, everything seemed normal. She stretched, her mind already focused on the economics homework she had to finish before the deadline. As she got dressed and prepared to leave for school, her mother entered the room, her expression unreadable. دخترم، امروز مدرسه "تعطیل است. طالبان کشور را گرفته اند (Dokhtaram, emruz madreseh ta'til ast. Tâlebân keshvar râ gerefte-and) — "My daughter, school is closed today. The Taliban have taken over the country."

Sophia stood frozen for a moment, the weight of her mother's words sinking in. She had never imagined the world around her could change so quickly, so drastically. The dream of going to school, of continuing her studies, seemed to evaporate before her eyes. She quietly sat on her bed, unsure of what to feel—fear, confusion, or a strange sense of disbelief.

Sophia stood at the window, her hand pressed against the cool glass. The streets below seemed the same, yet somehow different — as if the world had quietly shifted overnight. A few months ago, her days had flowed with the rhythm of routine: the dawn prayers echoing from the mosque, the sounds of children running through the streets, and the steady pulse of school life. She had walked those familiar paths with a sense of purpose, her textbooks filled with hopes of studying economics. The world was wide, filled with opportunity, and she was determined to chart her course. But now, all of that felt like a distant dream.

After the Taliban took control, everything changed. The schools closed. At first, there was talk of online classes, a flicker of hope that things might return to normal. "به هر حال، امید به زندگی باید داشت." — "After all, one must always hold onto hope in life," her mother had told her, trying to ease the uncertainty that hung in the air. But the internet was unreliable, and the lessons were fragmented, leaving Sophia's dreams of studying economics slipping further away. Instead, nursing textbooks became her reality — filled with medical terminology and practical science. It wasn't

what she had envisioned for herself, but she couldn't complain. Her mother had always reminded her, "هر چیزی که خداوند بخواید، همان می شود" — "Whatever God wills, that is what will be."

Weeks turned into months, and the online classes became a hollow ritual, a faint shadow of the education she had once known. The internet would drop, teachers struggled to find the right materials, and when the school finally reopened, it wasn't the same place she had left behind. Desks were arranged in rows, and the air in the classroom felt thick with tension. The curriculum had shifted entirely, focusing on medical sciences, with little room for her aspirations in economics. "گلابی که می خواهی بخوری، باید رنج" — "The rose you want to smell, you must endure its thorns first," Sophia thought, trying to find some peace in the situation, even though the reality was far from what she had hoped for.

Her nursing classes were now her entire world, with the study of human anatomy, patient care, and biology taking precedence over her dreams of global markets and economic theories. The government had made it clear that foreign models — particularly

Western approaches to medicine — were no longer acceptable. They had rewritten textbooks, removing any references to European healthcare systems. Instead, the focus was on local practices, ones that aligned more closely with the new policies. Sophia could feel the walls closing in, her dreams becoming smaller with each passing day.

At home, her mother noticed the change in her daughter. "Be patient, my daughter. God is always beside you." The words were comforting, but they didn't ease the ache in Sophia's chest. She had always believed in the power of patience, a lesson from Imam Ali: "کسی که صبر کند، پیروز می شود" — "He who is patient will triumph". But the weight of unspoken frustrations pressed down on her. She loved medicine, but economics had always been her true calling. Now, she was stuck in a life she hadn't chosen, her dreams fading like smoke in the wind.

Her fingers brushed against the edge of her nursing book. "What you want, you must fight for," she remembered her

uncle's words. The world outside had changed, and so had her future.

Today is Muharram. The house holds a quiet heaviness, a sacred stillness that seems to echo through its walls. Sophia sits beside her mother in the dimly lit living room, where the flame of a single candle flickers gently. Her mother rocks slowly, rhythmically reciting a noha in a low, sorrowful voice.

مگر از دل خونین تو، که گناه ماست، کربلا از خون تو، همیشه جاوید"

است" — *Magar az del khunin to, ke gonâh mâst ,*
Karbala az khun to, hamesha jâvid ast — "It is through your bleeding heart, that our sins are forgiven; Karbala remains eternal in your blood." The words hover in the air, filling the room with their mournful resonance.

There are no public processions, no communal majlis, no banners in the streets. Everything must remain within the safety of the home. In whispers and careful glances, the household remembers the legacy of Imam Hussain. Outside these walls, devotion must wear silence like a cloak.

On a nearby table, a worn booklet containing the sayings of Imam Ali lies open. One page is marked — صبر دو نوع است: صبر بر چیزی که دوست نمی داری و صبر بر چیزی "که دوست داری — Sabr do no' ast: sabr bar chizi ke dust nemi-dâri va sabr bar chizi ke dust dâri — "Patience is of two kinds: patience over what you dislike, and patience over what you love." The quote lingers in Sophia's mind as she folds the black scarf over her head and prepares the tea her mother will serve after the recitations.

From the corner of the room, the television remains off. The family avoids unnecessary attention — no loud gatherings, no visitors, no display of their mourning beyond the threshold. Their grief, like their faith, is practiced behind closed doors. A sense of quiet alertness hangs in the air.

The lines of another noha rise from her mother's lips, soft but steady:

هر گام تو، زمین در خون رنگین است، در جنگ بین حق و باطل، تو "همیشه پیروز بودی — Har gâm to, zamin dar khun rangin ast, dar jang beyn haq o bâtil, to hamesha pirooz budi — "Each step you took stained the ground in blood; in

the war between truth and falsehood, you were always victorious."

Just as her mother's voice trembles on the final verse, a sudden noise drifts in through the cracked window. Sophia pauses, her hands still over the teacups. From the alleyway, the unmistakable scrape of metal against stone — folding chairs being dragged out — followed by the burst of static from a television being tuned. A group of neighborhood boys, led by an eager teenager in a green jersey, had set up a small screen outside, balancing it on a makeshift stand.

Amurmur rises from the crowd as the match begins

Rahmanullah Gurbaz dar

("رحمان الله گرباز در مقابل استارک" —

moghâbel-e Starc) — Rahmanullah Gurbaz opens with sharp focus, sending the ball racing across the dusty alley with each cheer. Ibrahim Zadran follows, steady and grounded. The crowd erupts at every boundary — voices rising, hands lifted — but all under careful restraint. No loud music, no flags waving. Just cricket, watched

quietly with tightened throats, under the cautious gaze of unseen eyes.

Inside, the rhythm is different. Sophia's mother continues the noha in a whisper, her voice worn but unwavering:

"خیمه گاه سوخته، دل ما را سوزاند" — Kheimegâh-e sookhte , del-e mâ râ soozând — "The burned tents still burn our hearts."

The flame of the candle dances, casting shadows on the walls like silent witnesses. The black cloth draped over the shelf is folded small, modest. The sorrow must remain hidden — folded like the châdor Sophia now wears even within her own home.

From beyond the courtyard, a different tension brews. Near the bazar, the white pickups of the Amar bil Ma'ruf wa Nahi an al-Munkar patrol slow through the street. A few shops had dared stay open longer than necessary. A fruit vendor quietly adjusts the position of his scale, while others look away, their eyes never meeting those of the officers. Back outside, the match shifts. Gurbaz is caught at mid-off — a sharp silence follows. Rashid Khan stands in next, and every eye watches. Afghanistan's score

trembles on the edge of hope. In the final overs, Rashid strikes back — a six over deep square leg, a boundary down the ground. The boys can't help but rise to their feet, clapping with suppressed joy. One glances toward the main road, making sure no patrol hears their celebration.

After the innings break, Naveen-ul-Haq bowls a tight spell. Australia's middle order begins to crumble — one wicket clean bowled, another caught at deep midwicket. The youth gathered outside can't hold back a gasp, but the sound is short-lived. One of them glances toward the alley — a quiet nod of caution. The patrols could pass anytime.

Inside the house, the family gathers closer in the hallway where the walls feel thicker, the windows more hidden. Sophia's uncle begins to recite Marsiya, his voice slow and heavy, describing the thirst of Ali Asghar, the loneliness of Zainab. A small tray of dry bread and dates is passed around, a humble niaz — no lavish spread, only the essence. In the corner, a simple black cloth hangs, handwritten lines from a noha stitched across it in fading thread.

Her younger brother had built a tiny alam from wood and foil — a quiet act of devotion that is shown only once, then carefully stored beneath his bed. یادگارِ "عباس است، اما پنهان — It is Abbas's symbol, but hidden , her mother had whispered. Even the drum-like beat of the chest during matam must stay gentle — more like tapping than striking.

Back on the street, Australia needs 24 runs in the final over. The bowler runs in. First ball 2 runs. Next ball, a wicket. The crowd inches forward, holding breath. Two more runs. Then, on the final ball, a swing and a miss — Afghanistan wins. Crowd starts celebrating "افغانستان زنده باد" — Afghanistan zindabad!

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At the same moment, Sophia helps her mother pour tea into small glasses. The kettle whistles faintly. In the hallway, the Marsiya has ended. A pause follows, and then a whisper:

"السلام عليك يا ابا عبدالله" — Peace be upon you, O Aba Abdillah.

Their lips move in unison, and in that sacred silence, grief and quiet pride coexist — like parallel rivers flowing through the same valley.

That night, after the cheers fade and the house returns to stillness, Sophia sits by the window with a pen in hand and a folded sheet of lessons she'll share tomorrow. "در خاموشی، صدای حق شنیده می شود" — Dar khâmushi, sedây-e haqq shenide mishavad — "In silence, the voice of truth is heard."

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